

ARLnow

Local is everything

You're Not Starting Over

Free career coaching for former federal employees in Alexandria and Arlington.

Turn your experience into new opportunities fast.



100% of this service is financed by a \$150,000.00 Federal Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Title I grant from Virginia Works, Alexandria/Arlington Regional Workforce Council, Alexandria Workforce Development Center, and Arlington Employment Center are equal opportunity programs. Auxiliary aids and services are available upon request to individuals with disabilities. To request a reasonable accommodation, contact us at 703-228-1400, VA Relay 711.



News

BREAKING: Takis Karantonis Wins County Board Special Election in Landslide

By **ARLnow.com**

Published July 7, 2020 at 9:00PM | Updated July 7, 2020 at 11:09PM



(Updated at 10:45 p.m.) Democrat [Takis Karantonis](#) will fill the [late](#) Erik Gutshall's former Arlington County Board seat.

Karantonis, an economist and the former director of the Columbia Pike Revitalization Organization, captured 62.4% of the vote. He overperformed among absentee ballots, with 71% of the more than 10,000 absentee ballots cast amid the pandemic.

[Susan Cunningham](#), who described herself as a “progressive Independent,” received 32.6% of the vote. A civically-involved professional and mother of two, Cunningham was [endorsed](#) in the race by John Vihstadt, the last non-Democrat to win a seat on the County Board.

Republican [Bob Cambridge](#), a former CIA instructor, received 4.8% of the vote.

In all, 19,866 votes were cast — a turnout of 12.6% of the Arlington electorate. That's below the 22,264 votes tallied in the [2014 special election](#), in which Vihstadt first won his seat on the Board.

Besides [taking place during a pandemic](#), today's election was also hampered by a relatively short campaigning period, and an election day just after the Fourth of July. Karantonis [won the Democratic nomination](#) in a closed caucus of about 250 local Democratic party insiders, as the party [decried](#) not having enough time to organize a broader primary or caucus.

Karantonis' initial term on the Board will run through Dec. 31, 2021.

In a press release issued by the Arlington County Democratic Committee, Karantonis pledges "true progressive policies and effective leadership."

"Arlington voters responded overwhelmingly to Takis' positive, issues-oriented campaign, surmounting the unprecedented challenges posed by the coronavirus to elect an experienced leader to the County Board," Arlington Democrats Chair Jill Caiazzo said. "Takis will be a leader for all Arlingtonians. He has the expertise and empathy to build on the impressive legacy of Erik Gutshall. We know he'll serve Arlington well."

During the campaign, Karantonis touted his status as an immigrant as a reason he'll be particularly effective during these fraught times for the country. He has been a resident of Arlington for 14 years, currently living with his wife in the Arlington Village neighborhood.

"As an immigrant and a first-time candidate, I did not expect to receive the overwhelming amount of support from Arlingtonians throughout every zip code in our county," Karantonis said shortly after the election was called. "Our victory is meaningful for two specific reasons: it is the recognition of my many years of civic engagement in Arlington and it serves as a testament to Arlington voters' expectation of true progressive policies and effective leadership."

Karantonis previously served as executive director of the Columbia Pike Revitalization Organization, and now directs micro-lending for the Ethiopian Community Development Council, an Arlington-based nonprofit. He serves as vice chair of the Alliance for Housing Solutions, and previously was president of the

Columbia Heights Civic Association and board chair of Arlingtonians for a Clean Environment (now known as EcoAction Arlington). A native of Greece, Karantonis lived and worked in several European countries before immigrating to the United States. He speaks eight languages.

Cunningham, in a statement, thanked her opponents “for a spirited and hard-fought race” and wished Karantonis well on the County Board.

“Tonight I want to thank each and every voter in Arlington,” Cunningham said. “And I also want to thank my daughters and my husband, along with an incredible army of volunteers, who pulled out all the stops during a pandemic. This was always an uphill battle — not just against my opponents but also against an entrenched one-party system in Arlington... I truly hope we started some important conversations about the perils of one-party rule and the need for greater accountability.”

“I hope all of our elected officials will get serious about transparency, accountability, and improved School-County collaboration,” Cunningham concluded. “I have been deeply honored to meet and talk with so many Arlington residents. I look forward to many more discussions in the future.”

More on the turnout from the county elections office:

Arlington Elections 
@ArlingtonVotes · [Follow](#)



100% of precincts have reported.
~135 outstanding provisional ballots. 126 because
voters issued Mail Ballot.
Turnout = 12.6%: 9,648 from Precincts, 10,294 Early
+ Mail. 52% of votes cast before Election Day.
[#ArlingtonHistory](#) [#VAsForVoters](#)
Until the next one [#Countdown2020](#)

8:56 PM · Jul 7, 2020



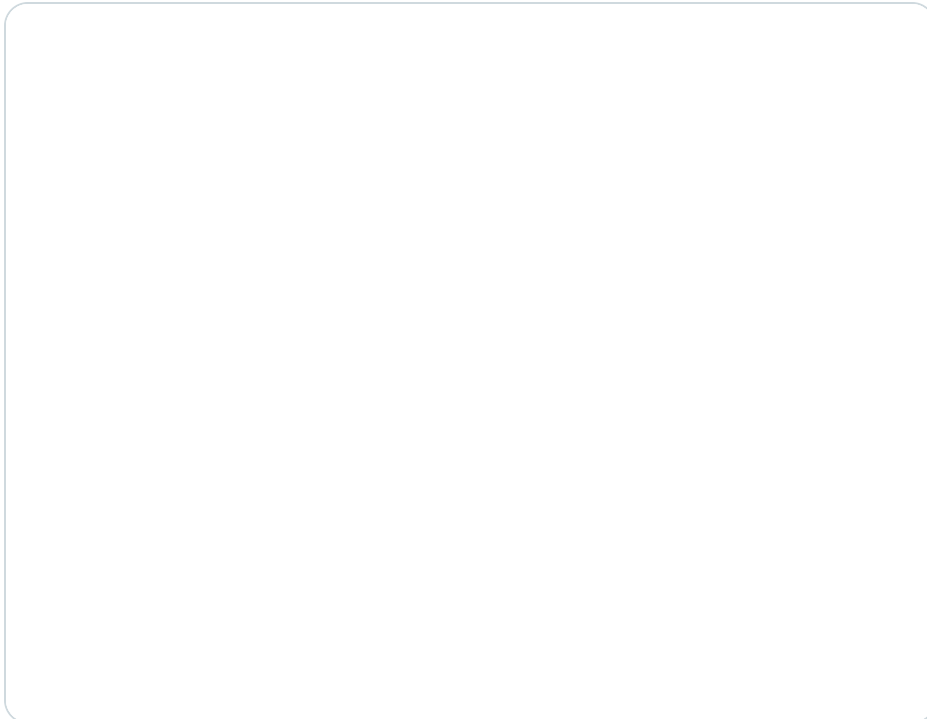
 30  Reply  Copy link

[Read 1 reply](#)

Arlington Elections 
@ArlingtonVotes · [Follow](#)



Arlington has a long history of Special Elections for County Board. Here's a snapshot of turnout. It's still pretty quiet at our precincts with 1 hour left to vote. What's your prediction for total turnout today?
[#ElectionData](#) [#Elections](#)



5:59 PM · Jul 7, 2020



7



Reply



Copy link

[Read 2 replies](#)

File photo

About the Author

